Winter Burrow

GM sheet · procedure

The hour loop

1. **Morning.** Roll 2d6 for weather. She leaves home at her top die.
2. **Each hour**, she marks it. Outdoors, she rolls Warmth, twice an hour at Night or in a snowstorm, never more. On 1–2 it steps down. At d4, a step down is a Chilled instead. Wet counts as a 1.
3. **Shelter**: no roll, and the crow's ladder resets.
4. **Read the same die.** By day, the crow. At Night, the owl.
5. **Arriving outdoors**, she throws that hour's Warmth die with two d6 of different colours. First d6: 1 is an encounter, 2 an omen (tracks, a feather, a silence where there was birdsong). Second d6: the table.
6. **Crossing the Brook**: DEX save or wet. Tobben's stones: no save.
7. **After a fight**, roll Warmth.
8. **Home.** Light the fire, one Hearth action, sleep. No fire, she sleeps Chilled. Door Forlorn: d6 each night, on a 1 something gets in.

Running it

- Say "roll Warmth". Never give the odds. The die on the table is the whole message.
- A save up to 5 over is a cost or a half success. Make the cost one she can see: an hour, a Warmth step, a dropped slot, a crow rung, a noise. A save with a named failure (save or wet, save or taken) stays pass or fail.
- The hours are on the track where she can see them. Turning back is her call.
- Don't announce what a room will turn up. Let her find it.
- **Foes** take damage like she does: HP, then STR and a STR save. Fail and it flees or dies. Running from something faster (fox, jay, owl) is a DEX save, or it gets one more attack.
- **She can't die.** When she goes down, end the scene and move to the next Morning. She wakes somewhere worse (where she fell, under snow, dragged off, or by a neighbour's fire once Underoak is full) with 1 HP, Warmth d4 and Injured. Clear all but one Chilled. Her bundles are lost. STR 0: she wakes at STR 1, Frostbitten too.
- The Weir is far on purpose. It probably takes clothes, a tool, and a friend's tunnel. One evening may not get there, and that's fine.

Weather

2D6	WEATHER	EFFECT
2	**Snowstorm**	Warmth twice an hour all day. Each leg of a trip costs an extra hour
3–5	**Sleet**	Wet in the first hour out
6–8	**Bitter cold**	Start the day one step below her top
9–11	**Overcast**	Nothing
12	**Clear, crisp**	Tracks show. The cat is on the Shed step

Encounters

D6	ENCOUNTER
1	A jay turning snow for seeds. It wants what's in her pack and will follow, loudly. 4hp, DEX 15, d6 peck
2	Nibs on the path, shaking
3	A web strung across the way, fresh and glistening. A web-weaver sits above it
4	By day, a fox, head cocked, listening at the snow. It hasn't heard her yet. 15hp, STR 15, DEX 15, d8 bite. At Dusk or Night, d3 wolf spiders instead
5	A wolf spider dragging something wrapped in silk. It hasn't seen her
6	By day, an ant column across the way. At Dusk, the owl on a low branch, watching. At Night, the owl rule

Sky and ground

Each threat has one answer. Fight spiders, hide from the crow, avoid the owl, wait out the ants.

The crow, Morning to Dusk

No stat block, can't be fought. Every Warmth 1 rolled in the open moves it a rung. On open ground (Long Field, the Brook ice, the Larch clearing) a 2 counts too. Any Salvage or keepsake in the pack: each counting roll moves it two rungs. Wet isn't a rolled 1.

1. A caw, far off.
2. A black shape on a high branch. It turns its head when she moves.
3. It drops. DEX save, or it takes a random pack slot and is gone. The ladder resets.

Resets under cover or at home. Show only the omens. Never name what it wants.

The owl, at Night

No ladder. In the open at Night, a Warmth 1 brings it (with a lit lantern, a 1 or 2). The roll still steps Warmth down. At most once an hour. It stoops: DEX save, no middle band.

Pass: talons close on snow. It can come again on the next 1. **Fail:** taken. She wakes at first light somewhere high, cold and alone (a branch, a beam, a ledge) with her pack, Warmth d4 and one Chilled. Getting down is the morning's first scene.

Fighting it is a last resort: 15hp, STR 15, DEX 15, d10 bite. Its critical damage is that it takes her.

Ant columns

A line across the path. Standing in it strips d3 Food a round. Going around costs an hour. The column moves on at Dusk.

Spiders

They live where it's warm and still: in shelter, down deep, and in the places worth reaching. A spider's place is out of the wind, so no Warmth roll there. That's the trap.

SPIDER	STATS	HOW IT FIGHTS
Web-weaver	6hp, STR 8, DEX 15, d6 bite to DEX	Waits in its web. She fights at disadvantage inside it. On critical damage it wraps her and drags her up
Wolf spiders, d3	3hp, STR 6, DEX 15, d4 bite	Hunt the open at Dusk, from more than one side
Broodmother	12hp, STR 12, DEX 12, Armour 1, d8 bite to DEX	Won't leave the egg sacs. On critical damage, d12 to STR

- Bites hurt DEX. At DEX 0 she can't move.
- Walking into a web: DEX save or stuck. Each STR save to pull free costs an action.
- Cutting a way through takes an hour. Fire clears a web at once and wakes everything nearby.
- In the open on a Bitter cold or Snowstorm day, spiders are slow and she always acts first. Luring one into the cold is a plan.
- A web cut down gives 1 Silk.

Nests

NEST	WHAT'S THERE	GUARDS
Larch hollow	1 web-weaver	Seasoned wood, each bundle counts 2
Pit, lower cut	Wolf spiders at Dusk	Rask's third cache, the moles' work
Shed rafters	2 web-weavers	The wool sock. The ash and scratches below
The back room	Broodmother, in the warm earth behind the chimney	Your mother's letter

The back room wakes when the Hearth reaches Simple. Something scratches behind the wall at night. Say no more than that.

Winter Burrow

Opening

Start at Dusk with two hours of light left, snow just starting. She has nothing to burn.

> *The beech is where you left it, bigger than you remember. The door hangs off one hinge. Inside, the hearth is grey ash, and the cold has got into everything. On the wall is a calendar, the days crossed out in pencil until the middle of last month. Then nothing.*

Ask: *What did you bring from the city that you couldn't leave behind?* It takes a slot, and it's hers to Remember.

Tonight's problem. Deadfall among the beech roots: an hour's work for 1 Wood. The Hedge is an hour away and has more. Without a fire she sleeps Chilled.

Marit

Marit kept the burrow alone after your parents went to the city. When word came that your mother had died, she stopped mending things. Late in autumn she walked to the Weir to fetch your mother's seed tin. The sisters had saved seed in it every year since they were girls, for the garden under the beech. The first snow caught her coming back. She is in the mill loft with a twisted ankle, rationing the seeds as food and ashamed of the state she left the burrow in. If she's found, she can be helped home, and a sled carries her. Nothing about how it ends is fixed.

The letter, in Aunt Marit's hand, late summer: *Come home before the snow. There is something of your mother's I want you to have, and I'd rather give it to you here.*

When she Remembers, give one small, concrete memory, never a conclusion. *Her hands red from the cold, knitting by this fire, never a matching pair.*

The wood

Hours from the beech, deep snow counted. Between places, the difference, at least 1. Every Brook crossing is a DEX save, or wet. A sled can't go into the Larch hollow, the Pit's lower cut or the Shed rafters.

PLACE	HOURS	SHELTER	GATHER	WHAT'S THERE
Beech roots	0	Home	1 Wood a day	Home
Bramble Hedge	1	No	Wood, Fiber, Food	A red mitten frozen on the thorns. Jays work the hedge in the mornings
The Brook	1	No	Stone	Ice over moving water. Tobben lives under the bank
Underoak	2	If welcome	Trade	A hollow oak along the hedge line. Rask lives in it, and Nibs stops here
Fallen Larch	2, across	The hollow	Wood: 1 an hour, 2 with a Hatchet	An open clearing. A fox listens here at Dusk. A hollow in the trunk is webbed shut
Gravel Pit	2	Below	Stone; Salvage with a Pick	A cut bank of old human digging. Agnes and Pil live below. Something hunts the lower cut at Dusk
The Shed	3, across	Yes	Salvage, Fiber (a wool sock gives 2)	A garden shed, door ajar. Webs in the rafters. Under the potting bench: ash from a tiny fire, two scratches on a floorboard
Long Field	5, across 4 boots	No	Nothing	Open snow, no shelter. Deep snow, so each hour costs two. Her staff stands upright halfway
The Weir	7, across 5 boots, 6 tunnel	Mill loft	Nothing	The old mill where Marit and your mother were born. A light in the loft, some nights

What the rooms turn up

ROOM	TURNS UP	IF REMEMBERED
Hearth	Pencil lines on the chimney stone, your height year by year. The last a hand higher than any child's	She measured herself the year you left, "so the wall wouldn't feel finished"
Door	The old bell, wrapped in a rag to keep it quiet	She stopped wanting visitors
Nest	A blanket in two wools, half neat, half hurried	Your mother started it. Marit finished it
Pantry	Full jars in her hand, one empty shelf marked *for the walk*	She packed for a long trip and meant to come back
Workbench	Your father's tools, a gap on the rack the shape of a small saw	She took it with her
Knitting	Her needles, still in a mitten with no pair	The red one at the Hedge is its twin
Back room	Your mother's last letter to Marit: *Save the seed. I'll come for spring.*	Why she went

Along the way: the calendar, the red mitten, Rask's rope trade, Nibs's lantern, the ash at the Shed, the staff in Long Field, then the light in the loft.

Neighbours

Each has a want, a grief and a gift. Play the grief through what they do. Let the gift follow from help, not payment.

WHO	WANTS	GRIEF	GIVES
Tobben, toad under the Brook bank. Awake when he should sleep	Dry moss for a bed (2 Fiber), and someone to sit with him an evening	His wife went down to sleep last autumn and didn't wake in spring	The stepping stones: no Brook save. Saw Marit cross late in the year, "with a pack bigger than her"
Rask, old red squirrel at Underoak. Forgot where he hoarded	His three caches found, at the Hedge, the Larch and the Pit. An hour's search each	Some mornings he forgets his own name	Each cache holds 4 Food, he gives her 2. His late mate's mittens pattern. Marit traded him honey for rope and asked about the Weir road
Agnes and Pil, mole sisters under the Gravel Pit	3 Wood cut with a Hatchet to shore the tunnel to Grandmother's chamber. Wolf spiders drive them off at Dusk	Pil says Grandmother is dead. Agnes won't let her say it. Grandmother is alive and very hungry	The tunnel under Long Field: 3 hours from the Pit, no Warmth rolls, out an hour from the Weir. The felted boots pattern
Nibs, shrew pedlar. Must eat every few hours or turns mean	A hot meal every time they meet (1 Food)	Everyone he loved is a day's walk behind him and keeps getting further	1 Salvage for 1 Food. The waxed cloak pattern. Marit's lantern (3 uses), her initials in the brass, for 3 Food

Underoak ◯ ◯ ◯ Fill a dot each time she properly helps a neighbour. At three, they start coming to her: someone at the door with Food, a paw on a Mend, a chair pulled up at her table. Where it goes from there is play.